

GRADE 8 · READING INFORMATIONAL TEXT · RI.8.7

A Shipwreck, Told Three Ways

Evaluate the specific advantages and disadvantages of presenting the same topic through different mediums, such as print text, video, and interactive multimedia.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RI.8.7: Evaluate the specific advantages and disadvantages of presenting the s...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Every medium has built-in strengths and limitations that shape what it can communicate well. Print text is easy to skim and revisit at your own pace but cannot show motion or sound. Video can show action and emotion but forces every viewer through the same pace. Interactive multimedia lets users explore at their own pace but requires more effort and technology to use well.

Modeled Example

A museum plaque about a historical event is limited to about 150 words. What is one advantage and one disadvantage of this print medium for telling the story?

An advantage is that visitors can read it quickly, at their own pace, without needing any device; a disadvantage is that 150 words cannot capture the same depth, emotion, or complexity that a longer format like video or an in-depth article could.

A documentary film about the same event can include survivor interviews with real emotion in their voices. What advantage does video have here that a printed pamphlet does not?

Video can capture tone of voice, facial expression, and emotional nuance directly, giving the audience an immediate emotional connection that a written transcript of the same words could only describe secondhand.

A Shipwreck, Told Three Ways (Part 1)

1. In 1898, the cargo ship Meridian Star sank off the coast of a small fishing town during an unexpected November storm, killing eleven of the eighteen crew members. Today, the story of the Meridian Star is told to visitors through three very different mediums: a bronze plaque at the harbor, a thirty-minute documentary film shown at the local museum, and an interactive website maintained by a maritime history nonprofit.

2. The harbor plaque, installed in 1953, contains exactly 142 words: the ship's name, the date, the death toll, and two sentences describing the storm. Visitors passing by on a walk can read the entire plaque in under a minute, absorbing the basic facts without needing to seek out a museum, a film screening, or an internet connection. Its main limitation is depth — the plaque has no room for individual crew members' stories, no explanation of why the ship was caught in the storm, and no way to convey what the disaster actually felt like to those aboard or waiting on shore.

A Shipwreck, Told Three Ways (Part 1), continued

3. The documentary film, produced in 2004, dedicates its full thirty minutes to interviews with descendants of survivors and crew members who died. One interview, with the great-granddaughter of a surviving deckhand, includes a long pause and a visibly shaking voice as she describes a pocket watch that washed ashore three days after the wreck. That specific emotional weight, conveyed through tone of voice and a trembling pause, is something the plaque's 142 words could never carry, no matter how well written.

A Shipwreck, Told Three Ways (Part 2)

4. But the documentary has its own limitations. Visitors must set aside a full thirty minutes and be physically present at a specific museum screening time, or seek out a copy elsewhere. Unlike the plaque, it cannot be skimmed for a single fact in ten seconds, and unlike a website, a viewer cannot jump directly to the one interview they are most interested in without fast-forwarding through the rest.

5. The interactive website, launched in 2018, takes a third approach entirely: a zoomable map of the wreck site, clickable profiles of all eighteen crew members with individual biographies, and an interactive timeline visitors can drag through hour by hour on the night of the storm. A visitor specifically interested in one crew member's story can go directly to that profile in seconds, something neither the plaque nor the documentary allows.

6. The website's disadvantages are just as real. It requires internet access and a device, immediately excluding visitors without either. It also demands more active effort from the user — clicking, exploring, deciding where to go next — compared to the plaque's effortless minute-long read or the documentary's guided, passive thirty minutes. A distracted or rushed visitor might explore only a fraction of the website's content, missing information that a linear documentary would have delivered to them regardless of their engagement level.

A Shipwreck, Told Three Ways (Part 2), continued

7. No single medium tells the Meridian Star's story completely. The plaque reaches the widest, most casual audience; the documentary delivers emotional depth no text can match; the website offers control and detail no fixed-length format allows. Together, and only together, the three mediums cover what any one of them, alone, cannot.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit facts does paragraph 1 provide about the Meridian Star disaster?
2. What explicit word count does paragraph 2 give for the harbor plaque, and what four pieces of information does it contain?

Guided Practice

3. What advantage of the plaque does paragraph 2 identify, related to how visitors encounter it?

4. What specific disadvantage of the plaque does paragraph 2 identify?

Guided Practice

5. What specific moment from the documentary does paragraph 3 describe in detail?

6. What advantage of video does paragraph 3 highlight, using that specific interview as evidence?

Partner Discussion

7. What explicit disadvantage of the documentary does paragraph 4 identify regarding time and access?

8. How does paragraph 4 compare the documentary's flexibility unfavorably to both the plaque and the website?

Partner Discussion

9. What three interactive features does paragraph 5 describe as part of the website?

Independent Practice

10. What advantage of the website does paragraph 5 highlight that neither the plaque nor the documentary offers?

11. What explicit disadvantage of the website does paragraph 6 identify regarding access?

Independent Practice

12. What second disadvantage of the website, related to user effort, does paragraph 6 describe, and how does it compare to the documentary?

13. According to paragraph 6, what specific risk does a distracted visitor face when using the website, that they would not face with the documentary?

Independent Practice

14. What is the article's overall conclusion in paragraph 7 about which medium is "best" for telling this story?

15. Create a two-column comparison for the plaque and the website only: one advantage and one disadvantage for each, using evidence from the article.

Small-Group Work

16. If a museum had to choose only one medium to preserve and could afford to fund only one, which would you recommend based on the article's evidence, and why?

17. What explicit installation and production years does the article give for the plaque, the documentary, and the website?

Small-Group Work

18. Why might the article include the specific year each medium was created? What does this detail suggest about how the story has been told over time?

19. Compare the kind of effort required from a visitor for the plaque versus the website, using specific evidence from the article.

Exit Ticket

20. Explain how the documentary occupies a middle position between the plaque and the website in terms of effort and control, using evidence from the article.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. It sank in 1898 off the coast of a small fishing town during an unexpected November storm, killing eleven of the eighteen crew members.
2. 142 words, containing the ship's name, the date, the death toll, and two sentences describing the storm.
3. Visitors can read the entire plaque in under a minute while passing by, without needing to seek out a museum, film screening, or internet connection.
4. Its lack of depth — no room for individual crew members' stories, no explanation of the storm's cause, and no way to convey the emotional experience of the disaster.
5. An interview with the great-granddaughter of a surviving deckhand, including a long pause and a shaking voice as she describes a pocket watch that washed ashore three days after the wreck.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. Video can convey emotional weight through tone of voice and a trembling pause, an effect the plaque's limited word count could never achieve no matter how well written.

7. Visitors must set aside a full thirty minutes and be physically present at a specific screening time, or seek out a copy elsewhere.

8. It states the documentary cannot be skimmed for a single fact in ten seconds like the plaque, and a viewer cannot jump directly to one interview without fast-forwarding, unlike the website's direct-access design.

9. A zoomable map of the wreck site, clickable profiles of all eighteen crew members with individual biographies, and a draggable hour-by-hour timeline of the night of the storm.

10. A visitor interested in one specific crew member's story can go directly to that profile in seconds, rather than reading unrelated information or sitting through an entire linear program.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. It requires internet access and a device, immediately excluding visitors who lack either.

12. It demands more active effort from the user (clicking, exploring, deciding where to go), compared to the documentary's guided, passive experience that delivers information regardless of how engaged the viewer is.

13. They might explore only a fraction of the website's content and miss information, whereas a linear documentary delivers its full content to a viewer regardless of their engagement level.

14. No single medium is best; each has distinct advantages the others lack, and only using all three together covers what any single medium alone cannot.

15. Plaque — advantage: readable in under a minute with no device needed (paragraph 2); disadvantage: no room for individual stories or explanation (paragraph 2). Website — advantage: direct access to specific crew profiles in seconds (paragraph 5); disadvantage: requires internet access and a device, excluding some visitors (paragraph 6).

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. Answers vary; a strong answer will choose one medium and support it with specific advantages from the text while acknowledging the specific information or effect that would be lost, showing understanding that every medium involves real tradeoffs rather than a single "correct" choice.

17. The plaque was installed in 1953, the documentary was produced in 2004, and the website was launched in 2018.

18. It suggests the story has been retold across generations as new mediums became available, with each new format adding capabilities (like emotional depth or interactivity) that earlier available technology could not provide.

19. The plaque requires almost no effort, readable in under a minute while walking by (paragraph 2); the website requires active effort, described as "clicking, exploring, deciding where to go next" (paragraph 6), a much more demanding form of engagement.

20. The documentary requires more time commitment than the plaque, since it takes a full thirty minutes rather than a quick read, but it requires less active decision-making than the website, since it is described as "guided, passive" (paragraph 6) rather than something the viewer must navigate themselves.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer